The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Mekhalā

Āryamekhalānāmadhāraṇī · Toh 907 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་མ་ེཁ་ལ་ཞེས་བ་ྱབ་ོའ་ིགཟངས།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Mekhalā, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Mekhalā Nāma Dhāraṇī and carrying a Tibetan title of the same meaning, is a short protective scripture centered on a spell, or vidyā-mantra, named Mekhalā. It opens in the Nyagrodha park near Kapilavastu, in the land of the Śākyas, where the young Rāhula, the Buddha's son, comes weeping to the Blessed One after being terrified in the night by a rākṣasa, a kind of demon. Moved to protect him, the Buddha tells the venerable Ānanda that he will teach this mantra and asks Ānanda to preserve it, and the text then invokes gods, nāgas, and other beings in its words of protection. It is Toh 907 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the class of dhāraṇī texts, the incantations and protective formulas gathered in that part of the canon.

In the language of India: ārya mekhala nāma dhāraṇī
In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Mekhalā.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the land of the Śākyas, at Kapilavastu, in the Nyagrodha park. At that time the young Rāhula, while lying in his bed, was terrified by a rākṣasa. When that very night had passed, the young Rāhula came out of Kapilavastu, led in front and surrounded by many youths, and went to where the Blessed One was. Arriving there, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, sat before him, and wept.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, to protect the young Rāhula I shall explain the vidyā-mantra called Mekhalā, and you must hold it.

"Hosts of gods, hosts of nāgas, hosts of yakṣas, hosts of rākṣasas, hosts of asuras, hosts of garuḍas, hosts of kinnaras, hosts of mahoragas, hosts of piśācas, hosts of pretas, hosts of kumbhāṇḍas, hosts of pūtanas, hosts of planets, hosts of lunar mansions, the twenty-eight yakṣa generals, the Four Great Kings, the sages free from desire, those who dwell in the snow mountains, whatever bhūtas are present in the ten directions, the hosts of sisters, Bāli, Kāṭalidi, Bodari, Village Ear, Sumanā, the great Hārītī, and the hosts of mātṛkās: listen to me!

"The guardians of the circle of the ocean are these: in the eastern quarter the rākṣasī called Hārītī, in the southern quarter the rākṣasī called Elephant Nose, in the western quarter the rākṣasī called She with Matted Locks, and in the northern quarter the rākṣasī called Crown of the Earth. Each of these fierce rākṣasīs is surrounded by a retinue of six hundred million. All of you who are named in the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā, provide protection!

tadyathā ghane ghane ghane ghane ghane ghane ghane ghane vati ghume ghume ghume ghume ghume ghume ghume ghume vati ghare ghare ghare ghare ghare ghare ghare ghare ghiririni gharavati svaravati dhanapati suravati ahime vatimati avati suvati bahuvati hala hala hala hala hala hala hala hala hili hili hili hili hili hili hili hili hili hula hula hula hula hula hula hula hula hulu tili tili tili tili tili tili tili tili tili hili hili mili mili petayava amane mavisare haha hihi samantrasare asamantrasare parikhasame abarte samantabarte ghane mekhale

"Ānanda, this one called Mekhalā, of great strength, endowed with miraculous power, of great diligence, is nowhere obstructed by vidyādharas, by bhūtas, or by vetālas; she goes everywhere without hindrance.

"Ānanda, this vidyā-mantra called Mekhalā was spoken by the buddhas, the blessed ones of the past, for the benefit of beings, for their happiness, and in order to provide them protection and shelter. Other great sages also said: 'Ānanda, the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā benefits beings. All those who are possessed of evil karma, who rob vitality, and who dwell upon the earth, on hearing the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā, become utterly terrified and flee into the directions and the intermediate directions.'

"Ānanda, for one who has properly taken up the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā, provide protection all around for twelve yojanas! Bring about complete safeguarding, complete upholding, complete guarding, peace, and well-being! Homage to the Buddha! Avert punishment! Ward off weapons and neutralize poison! Turn back enemies! Seal the boundaries! Bind with the thread! Turn back all hostility! Do not let humans and nonhumans who do evil cause harm! Homage to the Buddha! May the bases of the secret mantra be accomplished! svāhā"

The rite for this is as follows. Having paid homage to the Tathāgata and offered flowers and incense, one should bind with the thread. One should apply anointing and massage, and bathe thoroughly. By this rite one should turn back all grahas and fully pacify all illnesses.

tadyathā tile bele vimale tamale hili niri sirimasara

When this vidyā-mantra had been heard,
All the lands began to quake,
The hosts of bhūtas were greatly stirred,
And the hosts of gods arrived as well.
The kings of the nāgas also came,
The kings of the bhūtas also came,
And the Blessed Maitreya went there too.
Brahmā and Indra also came;
Maheśvara (Śiva) and Kumāra (Skanda),
Both of them arrived there too.
Whatever bhūtas are named
In the Mekhalā also came.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Maitreya said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I too shall grant to this one protection, complete safeguarding, complete upholding, peace, well-being, the averting of punishment, the warding off of weapons, the neutralizing of poison, the turning back of enemies, the sealing of boundaries, and complete turning back through the Mekhalā.

tadyathā abaṭṭani baṭṭani ibibaṭṭani culucili urdhadānte samanta dānte niramuṇḍe nimimuni I shall bring about peace and well-being! svāhā Homage to the Buddha! May there be well-being! svāhā"

Then at that time Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, offered these words as a supplement to this all-upholding vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā.

syādyathedan aṅgure adure dudure śikhi śikhi śikhi śikhi śikhi bare daradarabati mucamucabimuca I shall bring about peace and well-being! svāhā

Then at that time the god Suyāma offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan praduṣṭe rudhirakarṇe gamabhīre durdeśenamuce muce śākyarāje I shall bring about well-being! svāhā

Then at that time Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan soḍḍe bedeḍe bhedaḍame danatili tilimili Give protection! I shall bring about well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the Great King Kubera offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan ghume ghume ghume ghume ghume uke muke jvale dalematiphale svāre sare adhipati I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the Great King Dhṛtarāṣṭra offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan dhadhare dhadhare dhāraṇī dhāraṇī dhāre acute muce murumuru I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so extensively, up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the Great King Virūḍhaka offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan aṇḍare paṇḍare karaḍe parapatre kariruhe karibhare kanakapaṭe durume kṣukṣu akṣime bakṣi I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then the Great King Virūpākṣa offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan jamalajamala dhiridhiri bhiribhiribhiri samantabhiri I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the god Candra, the Moon, offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan alahe telabhe maḍe bimaḍe dhake dharake sakini bakini I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the god Sūrya, the Sun, offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan oṃ bāde bimale prabhāsvare śaharasme hasahasvarasme atasvarasi I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of gods offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan kurukuru surusuru murumuru I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of the lunar mansions offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan tamala tale ahe dahe ākāśābimale I shall work until peace and well-being come about! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of nāgas offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedana elemele acale padhe āśubadhemokṣe I shall work until peace and well-being come about! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of asuras offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan adhadhare bibute sampute danti I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the twenty-eight yakṣa generals offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan chachapati chachapati rurudrārā ubhirabharā I shall work until peace and well-being come about! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of pretas, piśācas, and kumbhāṇḍas offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan bhūtibibhūti atibhūti sarbartanabhūti I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the hosts of pūtanas and kaṭapūtanas offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan phadume kārāḍe adhita cute samiraṇi chuchubati I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time all the hosts of mātṛkās offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan kelemakele ḍama keleparaḍare ḍamareḍaḍare I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries!

svāhā

Then at that time the four great rākṣasīs of the four directions offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan āna bane khaje khabaje khukhuriri mirihiri I shall bring about peace and well-being! I shall do so up to the sealing of the boundaries! svāhā

Then at that time the great rākṣasī, the Soaring One, offered a supplement to the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā:

syādyathedan daradare daradare haha hihi huhuhuhu śikiklibakliba makhumakhu jukhakhi ṭapaṭapi aṭṭyuraṭṭyuṭyura klama kujukuju dridridri dūdūdū chimilimili aḍakvakvakvakasi dudu tithitithi timilimiti śiti mitili bati pretripetriṇe duhini ahāni lahe bahe thaṭapaithape

Venerable One, this is the vidyā-mantra of the Soaring One, offered as a supplement to the dhāraṇī-mantra of Mekhalā. I shall bring about protection, complete safeguarding, complete upholding, complete guarding, peace, well-being, the averting of punishment, the warding off of weapons, the neutralizing of poison, the turning back of enemies, the sealing of the boundaries for twelve leagues, and complete guarding.

May no god, nāga, yakṣa, rākṣasa, kumbhāṇḍa, piśāca, gandharva, preta, pūtana, kaṭapūtana, asura, garuḍa, kinnara, or mahoraga, no withering spirit, spirit of forgetfulness, spirit of madness, or slayer, no sorcery spirit (kākhorda) or vetāla, no one-day, two-day, three-day, or four-day fever, no human or nonhuman whatsoever cause harm! Whether one mocks, inflicts injury, watches for an opening, or seeks an opening, it is impossible that one should find an opening, except through the karmic maturation of former deeds. Amid all fears and from all nonhumans, may there always be well-being, svāhā.

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, take up the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā together with its accompanying parts. Ānanda, this vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā binds the clouds, suppresses the wind, subdues, protects oneself, protects others, protects villages and towns, and seals the boundaries. It cannot be transgressed by any god, nāga, yakṣa, rākṣasa, preta, kumbhāṇḍa, piśāca, or kaṭapūtana, by any śramaṇa, brahmin, caraka, wandering ascetic (parivrājaka), naked ascetic, Ājīvika, skull-bearer (kāpālika), or ash-pale ascetic, by any human or nonhuman.

"Ānanda, this vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā destroys all slayers, sorcery spirits, and vetālas. It averts all grahas. It destroys everything inauspicious.

"Ānanda, this vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā cuts off what is done by śramaṇas. It cuts off the spells made by brahmins, carakas, wandering ascetics, and Ājīvikas. It cuts off the spells made by Maheśvara (Śiva). It cuts off the spells made by Brahmā, by Śakra (Indra), by Indra, lord of the gods, by the Great King, by Viṣṇu, and by the king Kāmeśvara. It cuts off the spells made by the Great Kings, by the yakṣa generals, and by the moon, the sun, the constellations, and the planets. It cuts off the spells made by gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas. It cuts off the spells made by those possessed of miraculous powers. It cuts off even the spells made by temple-dwellers. It cuts off the spells made by charnel-ground dwellers. It cuts off the spells made by those dwelling at the foot of trees, those dwelling at the foot of mountains, those dwelling on mountain peaks, those dwelling on the earth, those dwelling in the sky, those dwelling in all places, by humans, and by nonhumans. This vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā cuts off; it cuts back; it cuts off hereafter.

"Ānanda, if someone uses this vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā to guard, to rescue, to hold, to protect, to bring peace and well-being, to avert punishment, to ward off weapons, to neutralize poison, to repel enemies, and to seal the boundaries for one league, two leagues, or up to twelve leagues, then I see no one, in the world with its gods, its māras, and its Brahmās, among its population with its śramaṇas and brahmins, in the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, who could transgress this vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā. That is impossible.

"Ānanda, by the truth of all the buddhas, the truth of the Dharma, the truth of the Saṅgha, the truth of all who speak the truth, and the truth of all the sages, let the hosts of sentient beings not contravene this! Ānanda, these are the five that must never be transgressed: the truth of the Buddha must not be transgressed, the truth of the Dharma must not be transgressed, the truth of the Saṅgha must not be transgressed, the truth of those who speak the truth must not be transgressed, and the truth of the sages must not be transgressed. They cannot be transgressed by any bhūta, any disease, any human, or any nonhuman. From all diseases, all bhūtas, all hostile ones, and all enemies, may there be well-being! Let no one assail! Let no one harm! Let no one strike, svāhā!"

I shall explain the rite of the vidyā-mantra of Mekhalā. Having presented to the Buddha offerings of flowers, incense, fragrances, and food offerings, one should afterward perform the protection. Being clean and wearing clean clothes, one should smear a maṇḍala with cow dung and strew flowers. Then,

seated in the midst of vases filled with whatever torma one can afford, or with flour, lotuses, food, drink, and flowers mixed together, or in the midst of filled vessels, one should remain there with incense burning without interruption. One should sprinkle everything with kuśa grass.

Protection of oneself and protection of others is done with a thread. To bind the clouds, one should perform a fire offering with jasmine wood and jasmine oil. To avert wind and rain, one should recite three times over a cord of muñja grass, and having applied the root vidyā-mantra to it seven times, tie seven knots. To accomplish a journey and make it go well, one should recite three times over the corner of one's Dharma robe and tie three knots. Having eaten the three white foods and fasted for three days and nights, one should recite twenty-one times over lotuses and white mustard seed and then seal the boundaries of villages and towns. One who wishes to cut off all spells should recite seven times over various weapons and cut through water with them. If one pours water into a new vessel, recites seven times, and bathes, all vināyakas will be bound. If one recites over white flowers and strikes with them, one becomes free of poison. For all diseases, one should sprinkle with branches of the karavīra tree. Having made protection for oneself, one should perform all the rites, wherever they may be, even for grahas.

In fights, disputes and quarrels, and in the circle of the royal palace, one should take sticks of atimuktaka firewood dipped in sesame oil scented with jasmine flowers, enchant them with the vidyā-mantra of the Soaring One, and perform a fire offering fourteen times.

One who wishes to bring bhūtas under control should take goat's milk, goat's butter and sticks of apāmārga firewood, enchant them with the vidyā-mantra of the Soaring One, and perform a fire offering five times.

One who wishes to perform a fire offering for the sake of all beings should take thick rice porridge, cow's milk, costus, salt and sticks of white karavīra firewood, and recite the mantra over them twenty-one times. If the fire offering is performed in this way, it becomes a fire offering performed for the sake of all sentient beings.

To obtain gain, one should take costus and sesame oil and recite the vidyā-mantra of the Soaring One over them seven times. If one smears this on one's face and then speaks, one will obtain whatever one asks for.

In every case, one should anoint the Tathāgata, or a stūpa of the Tathāgata, with perfumes, garlands, ointments, flowers, incense, powders and unguents,

and should also present food offerings to the extent one is able. Then this will actually be accomplished.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda, the young Rāhula, that entire assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the noble dhāraṇī called Mekhalā.

Through it, together with its protection and its ritual, may all sentient beings of the Sahā world be protected. svāhā

Translated, edited and finalized by the Indian preceptor Prajñāvarman and the chief editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

Translator's Notes

• Three of the four rākṣasīs of the quarters (Elephant Nose, She with Matted Locks, Crown of the Earth) and the figure "Village Ear" could not be securely identified with Sanskrit forms, so they are translated by meaning. "Sumanā" for Yid bzangs is a probable but not certain identification. In the rite, the written bya ba pa makes no sense in context and has been read as byug pa, "anointing." Chad pa in this protective list is taken as "punishment" (Skt. daṇḍa), not in the philosophical sense "annihilation." The end of the quotation from the "other great sages" is not marked in the Tibetan; it has been closed after the sentence about the beings fleeing.
• The name of the great rākṣasī, literally "Going-Soaring," could not be identified with a Sanskrit form with confidence. It is rendered by its meaning as "the Soaring One," the form used for this name elsewhere in this text. In Kubera's section the text reads "rigs sngags" for "rig sngags"; it is translated as vidyā-mantra, as elsewhere.
• "Ward off weapons" reads the evident mtshon cha for the written mtshan cha. "Avert punishment" renders chad pa spang ba as in the preceding passage, where chad pa is punishment (Skt. daṇḍa), not the philosophical 'annihilation'. Several spirit classes (withering spirit, spirit of forgetfulness, spirit of madness, slayer) are rendered by meaning, as their Sanskrit equivalents are not certain. "Ash-pale ascetic" renders lus skya ("pale-bodied") by meaning. "Temple-dwellers" renders lha khang ba by meaning. The king called Kāmeśvara ("lord of desire") is a reconstruction of the name.
• The phrase rendered "the vidyā-mantra of the Soaring One" is literally "the vidyā-mantra of the one who goes soaring." It may refer to Garuḍa or to a spell named earlier in the text. It could not be securely identified. The phrase "jasmine flowers" translates "sna ma'i me tog," which is commonly identified as jasmine (jātī or sumanā). "Salt" translates rgyam tsha, which is rock salt.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those

texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.